

Java's goal: Tao shows the way?

Java. If you can't program in it or aren't planning some fancy trading application based on it then, my friend, you are decidedly video-switch era. More likely you'll be relearning what it was like before the mouse came along; because the Java Development Kit is character-oriented. And you're loving it: The Enter key never felt so good. To you, despite its current primitive development tools, Java represents the next generation of financial applications. To Java inventor Sun Microsystems Inc., however, Java has more—much more—to do with the Walkman you're listening to while you code than it has to do with the trading room.

It's Sunday, the day before my editorial deadline and as I scramble to get this into print it is no day of rest. But then again it never is: Like many other single, home-alone males, Sunday for me is synonymous with one of the least pleasant chores in domestic life. Yes, it's laundry day.

How nice it would be, I thought as I loaded up my washing machine—sorting clothes by fabric and color—if this whole laborious (and for me confining) business could be automated. A microprocessor-controlled intelligent washing machine that could sense the labels on clothes, reject those that shouldn't be washed together and select the right wash program. That's what I need, I determined. And so, of course, my mind turned almost immediately to Java.

Java is one of the hottest subjects around right now: a language that makes Websites come to life by turning what is essentially a passive request/response display facility into a dynamic interactive client/server environment. By using an appropriate Web browser—the 32-bit version of Netscape Communications Corp.'s Navigator 2 is suitable—applications written in Java can be downloaded to a user's PC where they execute locally. Whether it's animating a film sequence on the Website for Toy Story (<http://www.bvi.co.uk/toystory/>) or shunting around real-time market data (see the Network Pricing Systems prototype on Fusion Systems Group's site at <http://www.fig.com/>), Java is being touted as a technology that takes the Internet way up the functionality curve. And so it does.

But when I thought of Java, it wasn't because I suddenly had a vision of virtual laundry over the Web. Rather, as



I engaged in the challenge of assessing the color-holding properties of polyester/wool mix, I remembered that Java had originally been conceived as a language that would bring intelligence to all manner of household appliances, consumer